

LIVING ON THE OUTSIDE: AFRICAN AMERICAN WOMEN BEFORE, DURING, AND AFTER IMPRISONMENT

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This article examines the multiple issues that contribute to the incarceration of African American women and threaten to render these women recidivists. These issues include but are not limited to substance abuse, sexual abuse, fractured familial relations, and abusive intimate relationships. In an attempt to examine these issues, the article explores how, prior to their imprisonment, social factors contravene African American women's attempts at enforcing their traditional roles as "women." The article attempts to show that the increased incarceration of African American women is part of a cultural phenomenon that reflects their social exclusion in U.S. society.

Historically, prisons have served as instruments of social control for both men and women. However, women have traditionally entered the criminal justice system for different reasons than have men. Generally speaking, women enter prisons for relatively minor crimes, such as property crimes, larceny, fraud, and forgery (Bureau of Justice Statistics, 1997, 1998). Women are less likely to be involved in violent offenses than are men. It has been found that when women do engage in homicide, such violence is generally characterized by the killing of an abusive male partner rather than the random killing of others (Browne, 1987; Rubin, 1987; Walker, 1989). That is, female homicide, it is argued, is usually a response to prolonged abuse by a man. But if, by most accounts, violent crimes by women have remained constant (DeCostanzo & Scholes, 1988; Walker, 1989), what, then, accounts for the increased number and proportion of incarcerated women, particularly African American women?

Since the mid-1980s, numerous studies have pointed to changes in sentencing laws involving drug-related charges as a primary factor in the

increased rate of incarceration among African American women (Nossiter, 1994; Richie, 1996; Rocawich, 1987). African American women are commonly cited as the demographic group with the largest incarceration rates where drug offenses are concerned (Free, 1996; Pollock-Byrne, 1990). Recent studies have reported, for example, that African American women make up more than 80% of imprisoned female crack cocaine offenders (DiMascio, 1995; Stuart, 1997). Where substance abuse offenses were once considered misdemeanors, these same crimes are now viewed as felony drug charges, carrying even longer prison terms (Baunach, 1985; Flowers, 1990; Staples & Johnson, 1993).

Drug offense aside, however, study after study indicate that African American women's criminal involvement arises from more complex social problems. Prior to her incarceration, for example, the profile that emerges of the African American female offender is that of a young, uneducated (French, 1983), single mother (Snell, 1994). She is likely to be unemployed, with few marketable skills (Baunach, 1985), and is more likely to be on welfare (Bresler & Lewis, 1983). Generally speaking, their being outside of the reach of mainstream experience translates into social exclusion for many of these women.

RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN SOCIAL FACTORS AND THE INCARCERATION OF AFRICAN AMERICAN WOMEN

Given their history of social exclusion, it seems almost certain that the social condition African American women face prior to their incarceration is marked by extreme powerlessness (Bickford & Massey, 1991; Sampson & Wilson, 1995). One such indicator is a history of sexual abuse both during their childhood years and as adults. Incarcerated African American women represent disproportionately higher rates of sexual abuse cases compared with women who have not been incarcerated (Chesney-Lind & Sheldon, 1992; Richie, 1996; Snell, 1994). Chesney-Lind and Sheldon (1992), for example, reported a variety of prior physical and sexual abuse rates ranging from 40% to 73% among African American female inmates. Richie's (1996) study of African American battered women in jail also revealed this pattern: 20 of the 26 battered women interviewed had been sexually abused in their intimate relationships as adults (p. 20), whereas 12 had been sexually abused as children (p. 48). Dougherty (1998), too, found that prior to their incarceration, many African American girls experience sexual abuse at home, suggesting that, generally, childhood abuse may place girls at increased risk of becoming offenders (Kline, 1992). Dougherty argued that sexual abuse of the

African American girl is almost always followed by running away from home, which often leads to shoplifting, prostitution, and drug-related activities. These illegal activities are almost always orchestrated by a boyfriend, which eventually leads to the arrest and incarceration of the girl.

Other social problems effectively contravene the attempts of poor African American women to carve out and maintain legitimate lives (Rafter, 1990; Richie, 1996). Their desire to fit into the ideological norm of creating successful family structures, for instance, frequently strikes discordant with the actuality of their lived experiences. In fact, desire for adherence to traditional gender roles often leads many poor African American women into unhealthy male-female relationships, which can have devastating personal and social results.

In her 1996 study of incarcerated, battered African American women, Richie used a sociopsychological analytical model to highlight the ways in which "gender entrapment" impedes the lives of these women. From Richie's viewpoint, the intersection of gender, race/ethnicity, and violence creates an "effective system of organizing African-American battered women's behavior into patterns that leave them vulnerable to private and public subordination, to violence in their intimate relationships and, in turn, to participation in illegal activities" (p. 4). She noted that many of these women ended up in prison as a consequence of going along with, for example, their mates' drug use (p. 122) because they had not only a profound interest in maintaining a traditional intimate relationship but also a fear of their partners' ire (p. 130).

But an even more striking finding in Richie's (1996) study is that many of the African American women participated in their partners' illegal activities, believing that such shared activity would bring the two emotionally closer. As important, these women hoped that their participation would not only prove to the men the extent to which they loved them but also end the physical and sexual abuse typically perpetrated by the men.

Part of the mechanism that helps determine these women's entry into the criminal justice system appears to be a desire to act in concert with expected gender roles within a stable, traditional relationship. Despite the fact that, for many, the dream of fitting into the gendered role schema is an elusive one, most of these women, unlike the men, do almost anything to sustain their doomed relationships. Jordan (1991) explained these women's responses by arguing that women tend to feel personally deficient—"something is wrong with me"—in taking responsibility for problematic relationships and, thus, seeking out ways to alter themselves. Jordan's point is supported by Bohlen (1989, p. A1), who argued that whereas, overall, African American women support their incarcerated and addicted partners, the reverse is not generally the case for their male counterparts; the men abandon their women. There-

fore, a prison term for an addicted African American married mother, when she is married, often means the loss of her child and the termination of her marriage. It almost certainly means that incarcerated African American women cannot rely on prolonged support from their partners (Bohlen, 1989).

Failed attempts to achieve stable, intimate relationships combine with still other social conditions to limit the choices of poor, incarcerated African American women. In *Psychotherapy and Counseling With Minorities*, Ramirez (1994) argued that with regard to female role expectations, poor minority women are often forced to straddle mainstream traditional gender roles and alternative, nontraditional lifestyles. Ramirez suggested that, as a group, poor African American women suffer economically when they opt for the traditional roles of mother and wife. Yet, when economic circumstances dictate that they veer away from these expected gender roles and, instead, engage in alternative, nontraditional lifestyles, these women then pay a great psychological price. Part of what Ramirez is alluding to is the inequitable socioeconomic arrangement in U.S. culture that plays itself out along racial lines (Currie, 1998; Rafter, 1990). Unlike White women, for example, who are often highly valued for their role as the "driving force behind the successful man" (Blakey, 1974), poor African American women too often get locked into a double bind by the socioeconomic structure. As a group, African American women are generally denied liberation of choice with regard to traditional and nontraditional roles, the first because of the economic paucity among African American men, the second because of the social stigma attached to living outside the boundaries of mainstream social values (hooks, 1981). Both sets of roles pose special problems for African American women, generally.

On one hand, African American men's historic lack of economic power (Blakey, 1974; Henriques, 1995; Sampson, 1987) has placed African American women in the unenviable position of usurping their male counterparts' expected "gender role" of primary "provider." Their role reversal has had deleterious effects on African American men (Blakey, 1974) and women (Bohlen, 1989; Wilson, 1987). It is not unusual, for instance, for the African American woman to find herself sole provider for her family. The U.S. Department of Commerce (1992) reported that in 78% of poor Black families, women head the household. Henriques (1995) noted that African American women "continue to find themselves . . . victims of black men's [economic] powerlessness" (p. 71). One consequence is that many of these women engage in behaviors they hope will offset their severe economic lack—drug-related activity, theft, prostitution, and so on (Richie, 1996). These behaviors, inevitably, lead to arrest and imprisonment.

On the other hand, for a variety of reasons, adoption of alternative lifestyles for the African American woman is not a viable option. Richie (1996) underscored the importance of understanding that whereas other "women" can weave in and out of mainstream society by adopting alternative identities and lifestyles, such options are not easily accessible to the average poor African American woman. For most low-income women of color, existence outside of the dominant society and nonconformity with the mainstream generally carry a heavy price, economically and socially. First, should the chosen alternative lifestyle fail (and there is every reason to expect that it will), the African American female transgressor has few economic resources on which to rely. Second, learned social values and mores still direct many African American women's sense of self (hooks, 1995). Most of the women in Richie's study help illustrate the sense of personal and public shame they experienced, even while engaged in deviant social behaviors.

It is the case that in U.S. culture, public perception has, historically, linked proclivity toward deviant social behaviors to African American women while tending to view these women as a monolithic group (hooks, 1981). Almost every African American girl soon becomes patently aware of this sentiment. As a result, a good many African American women walk a tight-rope with regard to their gender status and social expectations. Many, in fact, avoid behaviors that even hint at falling outside of societal boundaries, choosing instead to behave in ways that are consonant with social values, to the detriment of many (hooks, 1981, 1995). Indeed, as Richie (1996, p. 3) observed, for many poor African American women in jail and prison, it is precisely because of their deep interest in fitting into traditional gender roles and their attempts to succeed at those roles that their failures are typically, although mistakenly, attributed to their individual shortcomings rather than to societal conditions.

Thus, it appears that the gendered roles African American women learn, aspire to, and seek so desperately to maintain work to imprison them. It appears, too, that these women have been imprisoned at various points in their lives in other, more symbolic ways (Richie, 1996). Imprisonment is made manifest, in large part, from finding themselves victims of social exclusion, victims of African American men's economic powerlessness, and the resulting verbal, physical, and sexual abuse stemming from these men's deep sense of frustration, itself a by-product of the inequitable social and economic arrangements in U.S. culture (Rafter, 1990; Sampson, 1987; Wilson, 1987).

In a sense, then, for many African American women being in prison is a familiar if not a learned process. For even prior to their incarceration, these women's lives were "confined by social conditions in their communities,

restrained by their families' circumstances, [and] severely limited by abuse in their intimate relationships" (Richie, 1996, p. 5). Thus, making the break with incarceration is likely to be made more difficult for many, if only because prison offers a "safe" but temporary environment from the harsh realities of life outside (Henriques & Jones-Brown, 2000). Clearly, these issues will have a significant impact on the lives of these women as they attempt to live successfully and legally in mainstream society.

PRISONS AS "SAFE HAVENS"

According to Henriques and Jones-Brown (2000), for some African American women, prisons have become a "safe haven," in that prisons may protect these women from abuse and battering. Additionally, prisons may offer the incarcerated woman a respite from the physical and psychological devastation associated with extensive drug use and abuse. But for many African American women, prisons as safe havens function as a double-edged sword. Although prison may temporarily shield these women from abusive relationships, it separates them from their children and from other adult responsibilities.

More than 170,000 children in the United States have a mother in prison or jail (*Justice Journal*, 1998, p. 4). Among African American female inmates, 69% have children below age 18 (Snell, 1994, p. 6). Because some children are unable to visit their mothers due to the remote and distant location of most prisons, it may mean that the ties between these mothers and their children will weaken or become completely severed (Henriques, 1996, p. 85). Not surprisingly, forced separation produces a range of debilitating emotions for incarcerated African American women (Baunach, 1985). Given that many are the sole providers for their children, these women's incarceration generally means that their children will end up in foster care. It should also be noted that incarcerated female addicts rarely, if ever, retain custody of their children without demonstrating great strides toward recovery, itself a daunting task.

Prisons as safe havens also mean that, upon their release, many incarcerated African American women must unlearn their sense of dependence. While incarcerated, these women soon learn they are not expected to think; decisions about every aspect of their daily lives are made by others (Clark, 1995; Rafter, 1985). This is not to suggest that prison control differs for male inmates; generally, however, these female detainees may be at greater risk of becoming dependent. More broadly, men and women in Western societies are typically socialized along gender lines. Men are generally socialized into

“power/dominant” roles; women into “love/empathy/dependent” roles (Foss, 1989, pp. 151-157). Therefore, whereas men tend to repeat their childhood experiences of victimization by becoming abusers, women tend to react to their childhood victimization by continuing on as victims of abuse (Dutton & Painter, 1981; Walker, 1980).

Such dual socialization may pose acute victimization problems for African American women in particular. Their unique vulnerability to private and public subordination and profound desire to “fit in” make this point more than likely. Consequently, these two factors may render the African American woman especially vulnerable to control and, thus, dependency within a controlled institution such as a prison. Clark (1995, p. 315) argued that prisons serve to infantilize inmates and encourage dependency as women are directed in their actions and told what to do, how to do it, and when to do it. Clark argued further that prisons, represented by officers, staff, and administrators, act as a chastening “parent,” imposing rules and sanctions, much like the model of a punitive parent who seeks to control the child through sanctions and punishments. In fact, prison, for many African American women, may function as a substitute for early family life. The childhood experience of many poor, incarcerated African American women is generally punctuated by estrangement from close familial ties (Covington, 1998; Richie, 1996).

Consequently, many poor African American female inmates whose lives were out of control feel relief from the restraints imposed by imprisonment; for some, however, dependence on the controlled prison environment can take over, resulting in an infantile state (Clark, 1995, p. 315). It bears repeating that control within the prison institution merely delays the tremendous personal and social challenges that await these women upon their release—problems that will almost certainly affect the ways in which these women negotiate life on the outside.

FRACTURED FAMILIAL RELATIONSHIPS

It has been suggested that familial disconnect characterizes the childhood experiences of most incarcerated African American women and girls (Covington, 1998, p. 121). Covington (1998) argued that psychological isolation occurs when those in a woman’s world fail to validate or respond to her experience or to her attempts at connection. Given the economic hardships experienced by many poor African American families (Staples & Johnson, 1993), the struggle to survive and eke out adequate livelihoods can privilege practical concerns over the emotional needs of children. Consider for a

moment some of the findings of income inequity levels from a number of studies. Median per capita income for African American families is three fifths that for White families (U.S. Bureau of the Census, 1995). Unemployment and poverty rates among African American families are twice as high as those among White families (Russell, 1998; Sklar, 1998; Taeuber, 1996). Between 1989 and 1993, the rate for African American married couples living below the poverty level was 12.3% versus 5.8% for White married couples, and the rate for African American female single-headed households below the poverty level was 49.9% versus 29.2% for White female single-headed households (Taeuber, 1996, p. 145). Sturrale (1997) reported that between 1976 and 1995, poverty rates among African American families doubled, with nearly half of these families living below 50% of the federal poverty level. Sampson and Laub (1994) found that economic inequity increases the rate of single-parent African American households, the majority of which are headed by poor single women (U.S. Department of Commerce, 1992).

These findings suggest that the stress of severe economic pressures can undermine the ability of poor African American mothers to adequately nurture their children (Duncan, Brooks-Gunn, & Klabanov, 1994). The impact of persistent economic strain often produces severe depression among these mothers (Leadbeater & Bishop, 1994), which can inhibit them from forming close emotional attachments with their children (Sampson & Laub, 1994). Sampson and Laub (1994) found that lack of emotional attachment between poor African American mothers and their children affects early childhood development. In turn, this lack can produce familial disconnect, a common feature among incarcerated African American women (Richie, 1996). According to an incarcerated African American woman in Richie's (1996) study,

My mother . . . worked for some wealthy white people. . . . She never missed a day of work. . . . Even though everyone depended on my mother, none of us were able to be really close to her. She was kind of distant, like she really lived in her own world; working and praying as hard as she did, she didn't let herself be open to anyone. . . . I resented . . . the lack of mothering she gave me. (p. 40)

Persistent poverty and poor parenting create environments that may increase the likelihood of participation in crime. Shihadeh and Steffensmier (1994) reported that high levels of economic inequity are related to high numbers of single-parent households among poor African Americans, which can result in poor parenting, which in turn can increase behavioral risks leading to

arrests. These insights help shed light on the conditions that profoundly shape the social experiences of poor, incarcerated African American women.

But beyond such concerns, economic inequity for poor African American women is part of an even larger package of social oppression. Violence rates among these women serve as examples. The *Statistical Handbook on Women in America* (Taeuber, 1996) reports that the overall victimization rate for African American women 12 to 15 years old is 92.7% versus 57.9% for White women, 77.7% versus 51% for those between 20 and 24 years old, and 48.1% versus 32.6% for those between 25 and 34 years old, respectively (p. 324). When broken down by victim-offender relationship, the picture is equally grim. For every 1,000 African American women age 12 years or older, 3.5 are victimized by a relative versus 2.6 per 1,000 for White women in the same age group, and the rate of victimization by an acquaintance/friend is 17.2 per 1,000 for African American women versus 12.5 per 1,000 for White women (p. 327).

Figures such as these support Garbarino, Kostelny, and Grady's (1993) findings, which revealed that childhood abuse is concentrated in the poorest African American communities. The researchers concluded that this phenomenon is primarily related to the stress associated with economic impoverishment. The level of abuse and neglect among women of this group distinguishes their early childhood experiences from those of other women. The above figures also illustrate that the interlocking systems of economic poverty among poor African American women are stronger than those of the family; the onslaught of pressures in the social environment combines to adversely affect individual behaviors (Currie, 1998). Leadbeater and Bishop (1994) suggested that multiple stresses work to undermine the ability of the families of many African American female inmates, despite families' individual efforts to supervise their children. Thus, it seems certain that the constellation of social and personal problems endemic in their families of origin works to socially alienate and emotionally isolate many African American female inmates from their families. Covington (1998) reported that strained familial relationships are almost always challenges for incarcerated African American women. Like Covington, Richie (1996) suggested that among the root causes of drug abuse on the part of many of these women, for example, is the lack of emotional attachment within these women's families of origin. To escape the pain and alienation, many women leave home prematurely, get caught up with the wrong influences and may become involved in drug-abusing behaviors.

Familial connections may become further fractured as a result of African American women's drug addictions. Prior to their imprisonment, some may have become erratic and, at times, violent with their families because of their

drug involvement. In turn, family members may have given up on the addict or may simply fear the volatile behavior of the addict. In describing the relationship she had with her family as a result of her drug addiction, an African American female offender stated: "I didn't burn bridges; I blew them up!" (Self-Taught Empowerment and Pride [STEP] Program interview, April 6, 1998). Severing of familial ties appears to be a common theme among these women. It is reasonable to assume, therefore, that for poor, incarcerated African American women, the confluence of poverty, violence, race, gender, class, drug use and abuse, failed intimate relationships, and fractured familial ties will combine to undermine their individual efforts as they attempt to live successfully on the outside.

ABUSIVE INTIMATE RELATIONSHIPS

The subject of male-female relationships is one of major importance for most women before, during, and after their imprisonment (Staples & Johnson, 1993). This is particularly true of the incarcerated African American woman (Henriques & Jones-Brown, 1998; Richie, 1996). Having been deprived of loving, affirming relationships in their childhood and denied positive affirmation in society, many seek to create such relationships with the men in their lives. But as has been observed, a common feature of the intimate relationships of poor, incarcerated African American women, especially those with drug-related backgrounds, is abuse and neglect. According to the *Statistical Handbook on Women in America* (Taeuber, 1996, p. 327), African American women experience physical and sexual abuse from intimates at a rate of 10.9 per 1,000. Despite the horrific abuse, many of these women continue to value and desire these relationships (Henriques & Jones-Brown, 1998; Richie, 1996), even when they acknowledge that such relationships are at the root of their problems.

Dougherty (1998) commented fairly extensively on the degree to which so many of these women come to view violence in intimate relationships as the norm. According to Dougherty, these female offenders may actually consider the fact that they are alive as proof that what they have experienced could have been far worse. In relative terms, they can always imagine something more hideous than what has happened to them, and that is what they are apt to define as abusive, not their own experiences. Henriques (1998) reported the comments of one woman recently released from prison: "As a child, I was sexually violated by an uncle. Nobody in the new home sexually abused me and I thought that something was wrong. I thought that they didn't care about me" (STEP Program interview, April 6, 1998). Childhood abuse

and neglect for many poor, incarcerated African American women foster acceptance of and participation in their own victimization (Richie, 1996). It is not surprising then that, according to Henriques and Jones-Brown, in order not to experience isolation, these women often forgive the men who violate and abuse them, and return to such relationships after imprisonment because of fear, familiarity, the desire not to be alone, or a sense of loyalty.

Such contradictions leave open great spaces for emotional and psychological oppression in the intimate relationships of these women. And because validation of the self through abusive, intimate relationships appears to undergird the emotional needs of the incarcerated African American female offender, she is particularly susceptible to being oppressed. One female ex-offender aptly described the dysfunction that characterizes her relationship: "He don't call when he says he will. When he finally shows up and I mention it, he beats me up. Then we have sex, and then he leaves. I don't hear from him again for weeks—till the next time, and then it happens all over again." When asked why she tolerates this treatment, her response was: "I love him" (STEP Program interview, April 6, 1998). The overwhelming importance of the intimate relational experiences of incarcerated African American women has been addressed and emphasized elsewhere (e.g., Belknap, 1996; Bloom, 1997; Henriques & Jones-Brown, 1998; Richie, 1996). This exposition of those factors that lead African American women into crime is clearly abridged. What is unclear is whether these women's criminal participation is rooted primarily in their learned gender definition, their economic marginalization, their personal inadequacy, or some other factor. Perhaps it is a combination of these. A need exists for criminologists and prison administrators alike to look toward a macro-social narrative of these women's experience in U.S. culture. Such a search could lead to meaningful solutions to help stem the disproportionate rate of imprisonment among African American women.

CONCLUSION

In this article, we studied those forces that intersect to propel African American women into the criminal justice system. We examined the way in which these women's imprisonment reflects their social position in the culture. We noted that economic constraints thwart many poor African American women's attempts at adhering to expected gender roles, and how such obstacles, in turn, help foster criminal behavior among these women. Further research is needed to better understand how these issues operate to contribute to such high incarceration rates among African American women.

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